STATE SCAN

MAHARASHTRA: IDENTITY FLUX PG 22

WEST BENGAL: BJP'S SPOKESMAN PG 24



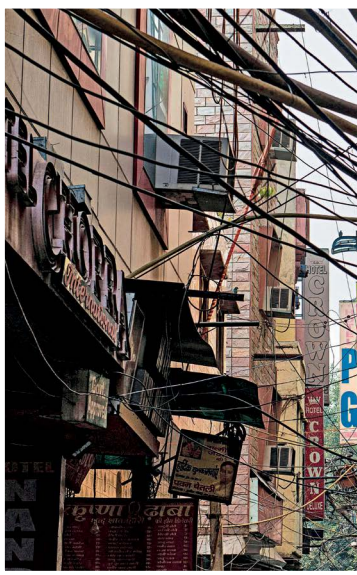
AP

▶ DELHI

CAPITAL APATHY

The Hauz Rani fire, which claimed 22 victims, bears all the marks of the capital's regulatory chaos. Let alone learning from the past, a booming Delhi careens ever closer to the brink in its daily life

By **Avishek G. Dastidar**



IT'S A LANE THAT COULD HAVE BEEN IN ANY of the scores of urban villages that dot Delhi. Dark, skinny backalleys where the sun doesn't reach, because it can't find a way through haphazardly stacked matchbox buildings without getting entangled in a drooping mass of power cables. Hauz Rani, sandwiched between Malviya Nagar and Saket, is no different from all those: it's a traffic jam of a village. But being across the road from the hospitals in Saket, a floating population of 'medical tourists' looking for affordable pads has been added on to its older residents and the usual crowd of cut-rate tenants.

Flourish Stay catered to them. It was built like the others: restaurant below, B&B above. It had the licence for six rooms, but ran about 28—the sort of infraction that usually causes no wrinkle in Delhi. Except that, on June 3 morning, this squat piece of architecture in five storeys played host to one of the deadliest fires the capital has seen in years. The likely cause: an electric oil fryer that overheated and sparked. As flames engulfed the kitchen, the chef in his panic apparently switched off the mains before fleeing. Unintentionally, that disabled the building's electronic door-locking system, trapping guests inside the rooms.